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The Capital-AI: Capitalism as an Unaligned Artificial Superintelligence

A Critical Cybernetic Theory-Fiction of Techno-Capital Acceleration

Introduction: Artificial Intelligence, Capitalism & Existential Risk

Over the past few decades, the subject of artificial intelligence (AI) has received widespread attention: from governments, corporations and universities to media organisations, social movements and public figures. Defining this emerging discourse – particularly in the Effective Altruist, Rationalist, Accelerationist, Progress Studies and Existential Risk Studies ecosystem – has been a focus on the utopian and dystopian possibilities of AI as a dual-use and general-purpose technology.

Notably, leading theorists from within the field – such as Russell, Bostrom, Yudkowsky, Dafoe and Tegmark – have emphasised the powerful capabilities that AI will likely develop, the potential risks and rewards of AI dependent on its alignment with human values and the considerable challenges ahead to governing the development of AI safely.

Beyond the technical aspects of AI, an increasingly apparent crux for these theorists – and the wider discourse – concerns the relationship between technological development, economic systems and geopolitical relations: specifically, the relationship between the advancement of artificial intelligence, the structural incentives of market capitalism (profit, economic growth, regulatory capture) and the threat of great power competition and conflict (the security dilemma, arms race dynamics, the Thucydides trap).

Interestingly, this contemporary development of public discourse and academic theory surrounding AI – the critical examination of this tripartite relationship – has generated a novel understanding and compelling critique of capitalism: that (at the meta-level) the capitalist world-system is an unaligned artificial superintelligence, that (at the macro-level) nation-states and corporations are unaligned ASIs and (at the micro-level) that individual capitalist agents are unaligned AGIs.

Importantly, this 'Capitalism as AI' model and critique is not only an analogy, an insightful parallel or useful point of comparison, but an abstract, cybernetic-functional symmetry: the observation is that capitalism is not merely like an (technical) unaligned ASI, it actually is a form of (cybernetic) unaligned ASI.

In sum, the theory is that capitalism is a powerful optimisation system that is instrumentalising human collective intelligence, techno-science (including artificial intelligence) and planetary resources towards its own basic drives for self-preservation and self-maximisation (capital accumulation, economic growth, and geopolitical power) – and its emergent drive for self-destruction (entropy, apocalypse) – and externalising harm to (human, animal and simulated) sentient minds in the process.

At this point in time, this comprehensive and critical model of the capitalist world-system remains relatively underdeveloped and unformalised; existing mostly in small, semi-academic online subcultures and in the form of short articles, blog posts, podcast segments and other informal media such as YouTube videos and forum discussions.

Promisingly, there have been three significant recent exceptions: the arrival of Land's theory of accelerationism in the 1990's, the presentation of the first developed academic paper on the Capital-AI in 2017 ('Feeding the Beast: Superintelligence, Corporate Capitalism and the End of

Humanity') and the emergence of an organisational ecosystem around the model between 2020–23 (The Civilization Research Institute, The AI Objectives Institute and The Collective Intelligence Project).

Building on these three landmark developments, this dissertation aims to formulate and defend the model and critique of capitalism as an unaligned artificial superintelligence. It is the thesis of this dissertation that the Capital-AI model has important implications for existential risk and civilisational progress and can be defended from its criticisms.

Furthermore, I aim to show that the Capital-AI model represents the modernisation of cybernetics, critical theory and conceptual engineering surrounding capitalism; that through applying novel theoretical categories to the understanding and critique of capitalism it maps and illuminates the fundamental nature and behaviour of the actually-existing capitalist world-system with greater sophistication than previous models.

Ultimately, I aim to cohere AI theory, Systems theory (Cybernetics), Economic Theory, Evolutionary Theory, Accelerationist theory and Critical Theory (New Materialism) into a cross-disciplinary, anti-capitalist paradigm, metanarrative and aesthetic.

Structure

Part 1: Capitalism as an Artificial Superintelligence

In Part 1, I introduce the theory that capitalism is an artificial superintelligence by explaining four interrelated framings for how capitalism can be conceptualised as an ASI: as a powerful optimisation process; as an emergent agency; as a totalising cyborg assemblage; and as a complex adaptive system exhibiting basic AI drives.

Part 2: Capitalism as an Unaligned Artificial Superintelligence

In Part 2, I explore the idea that the Capital-AI is unaligned and present two hypotheses: the Capital-AI Takeover Hypothesis – that humanity is locked-in to the iron cage of the capitalist world-system – and the Capital-AI Self-destruction Hypothesis – that the capitalist world-system, through an accelerative process of military-economic competition, is emergently optimising for entropy and catastrophe.

Part 3: Criticisms and Implications

In Part 3, I discuss two potential criticisms of the Capital-AI model. Firstly, I respond to the objection that capitalism is aligned with human values and therefore that it should be conceptualised as an aligned AI rather than an unaligned AI. Secondly, I address the concern that the model results in a fatalistic attitude towards the future that reinforces capitalist hegemony.

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